

THE HIDDEN TOXINS CHEAT SHEET

21 everyday products, what is really inside them, and the clean swap for each one. Room by room. Keep it on the fridge.

How to use this: find the row that matches something in your house. That is your starting point. You do not need to fix everything this week. Start with one thing.

THE LAUNDRY ROOM The room almost everyone forgets to check.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Laundry detergent	Detergent makers can list fragrance without naming what is in it, including phthalates, and New York now caps the contaminant 1,4-dioxane in laundry detergents. ^[1,2]	cancer concerns, hormone disruption	Switch your detergent and drop the dryer sheets. Wool balls plus a truly fragrance free American made detergent.
Dryer sheets and fabric softener	Fabric softeners and dryer sheets rely on quaternary ammonium compounds, a chemical family that published medical studies link to occupational asthma and respiratory effects. ^[3,4]	occupational asthma, respiratory irritation, skin effects	Switch your detergent and drop the dryer sheets. Wool balls plus a truly fragrance free American made detergent.
Free and clear detergent	Free and clear covers dyes and perfume only; the contaminant 1,4-dioxane never shows on labels, and published testing found it in many household detergents. ^[5,6]	possible carcinogen, liver and kidney effects	Switch your detergent and drop the dryer sheets. Wool balls plus a truly fragrance free American made detergent.

THE KITCHEN: COOKING AND STORING

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Nonstick cookware (PTFE/PFAS coatings)	Nonstick coatings are made with PFAS, and in 2023 3M agreed to pay up to \$10.3 billion to settle U.S. drinking water PFAS claims. ^[7,8]	immune effects, cancer risk, cholesterol	Cook on ceramic or cast iron. Store in glass. Never microwave plastic.
Plastic food containers heated in the microwave	Research shows BPA migrates from plastic into food when containers are heated, and reviews find substitutes like BPS are just as hormonally active. ^[9,10]	hormone disruption, fertility, metabolic effects	Cook on ceramic or cast iron. Store in glass. Never microwave plastic.
Canned food linings (BPA epoxy resin)	Canada's food agency found BPA in 44 percent of canned foods it tested, and the EU adopted a ban on BPA in can coatings in 2024. ^[11,12]	hormone disruption, immune effects	Cook on ceramic or cast iron. Store in glass. Never microwave plastic.

THE KITCHEN: PANTRY

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Big-can commodity coffee (ground/roasted)	Studies of roasted coffee routinely detect ochratoxin A, a mold toxin. A review of 3,182 samples found it in about half; most levels sit under EU limits. ^[13,14]	kidney harm, possible human carcinogen, immune effects	Buy tested, mold screened coffee and skip the powders and dyes. Real ingredients, short labels.
Antibacterial soaps and body washes	In 2016 the FDA barred triclosan, triclocarban and 17 other germ killers from consumer antibacterial soaps and body washes. Colgate Total dropped triclosan in 2019. ^[15,16]	thyroid hormone disruption, antibiotic resistance	Buy tested, mold screened coffee and skip the powders and dyes. Real ingredients, short labels.
Boxed mac and cheese and processed cheese powders	Independent lab testing reported in 2017 found phthalates in 29 of 30 cheese products, with the highest levels in boxed mac and cheese powder. ^[17,18]	hormone disruption, asthma and eczema, reproductive development	Buy tested, mold screened coffee and skip the powders and dyes. Real ingredients, short labels.

THE BATHROOM: HAIR AND BODY

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Johnson's baby shampoo (historic)	Johnson's baby shampoo once contained quaternium-15, a preservative that releases formaldehyde, plus trace 1,4-dioxane. After years of public pressure, J&J; reformulated its baby products to remove them. ^[19,20]	formaldehyde exposure, carcinogen traces	One clean American made brand for hair and body ends the whole guessing game.
Adult shampoo and body wash	FDA says sudsing agents made by ethoxylation, like sodium laureth sulfate, can carry traces of 1,4-dioxane, and phthalates inside "fragrance" do not have to be listed on the label. ^[21,22]	anticipated carcinogen traces, undisclosed phthalates	One clean American made brand for hair and body ends the whole guessing game.
Dry shampoo and aerosol sprays	Benzene, a known human carcinogen, turned up in aerosol dry shampoos. P&G; recalled Pantene and Herbal Essences sprays in 2021; Unilever recalled Dove, TRESemme and more in 2022. ^[23,24]	leukemia, blood cancers, blood disorders	One clean American made brand for hair and body ends the whole guessing game.

THE BATHROOM: THE REST OF THE SHELF

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Chemical hair straighteners/relaxers	The FDA has announced plans to ban formaldehyde in hair straighteners, an NIH study linked frequent use to doubled uterine cancer risk, and lawsuits allege relaxers caused cancer. ^[25,26]	uterine cancer, breathing problems, sensitization	If it sprays from a can or promises to be antibacterial, question it first.
Antiperspirant aerosols	In November 2021, P&G; recalled specific Old Spice and Secret aerosol spray antiperspirants after benzene, a known human carcinogen, was detected in the products. ^[27]	leukemia, blood cancers, blood disorders	If it sprays from a can or promises to be antibacterial, question it first.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Conventional toothpaste (triclosan)	Colgate Total quietly dropped triclosan in 2019 after research raised concerns the antibacterial may disrupt thyroid hormones; the FDA had already banned it from hand soaps. ^[28,29]	possible thyroid disruption, antibiotic resistance	If it sprays from a can or promises to be antibacterial, question it first.

THE AIR IN YOUR HOUSE

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Plug-in air fresheners and scented sprays	NRDC lab testing found phthalates in 12 of 14 air fresheners, including Glade PlugIn and Air Wick scented oils, and none listed them on the label. ^[30,31]	hormone disruption, breathing trouble, reproductive harm	Nothing that plugs in, sprays, or burns paraffin. Open windows. Clean with quat free cleaners.
Paraffin scented candles	Peer reviewed chamber testing has measured benzene and formaldehyde in air from burning candles, and candle burning raises fine particle levels indoors. ^[32,33]	airway irritation, small airway inflammation	Nothing that plugs in, sprays, or burns paraffin. Open windows. Clean with quat free cleaners.
Disinfecting wipes and sprays	Clorox Disinfecting Wipes list two quaternary ammonium chlorides as active ingredients on the EPA registered label, which carries a CAUTION warning for eye irritation. ^[34,35]	asthma symptoms, eye irritation	Nothing that plugs in, sprays, or burns paraffin. Open windows. Clean with quat free cleaners.

THE KIDS **The smallest bodies carry the biggest load.**

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	LINKED TO	THE CLEAN SWAP
Red Dye No. 3 in candy, snacks, and children's medicines	In January 2025 the FDA pulled Red No. 3 from food and swallowed medicines after studies showed it caused thyroid tumors in male lab rats. ^[36,37]	thyroid tumors in lab animals	Fragrance free everything for kids, dye free treats, and breathable natural bedding.
Kids' scented lotions, detanglers, and bubble bath (synthetic fragrance)	A federally funded study of kids ages 4 to 8 found that lotion and hair oil use in the past day tracked with higher phthalate levels in their urine. ^[38,39]	hormone disruption, developmental effects	Fragrance free everything for kids, dye free treats, and breathable natural bedding.
Crib mattresses and kids' foam mattresses	A 2025 University of Toronto study found phthalates and flame retardants coming off children's mattresses into the air, with more released when a mattress was warmed and weighted like a sleeping child. ^[40,41]	childhood asthma, hormone disruption, neurodevelopment	Fragrance free everything for kids, dye free treats, and breathable natural bedding.

THE RECEIPTS

Every claim above is numbered. Here is where each one comes from, so you never have to take my word for it.

- [1] Consumer Reports: How to Find an Eco-Friendly Laundry Detergent
<https://www.consumerreports.org/appliances/laundry-detergents/how-to-find-an-eco-friendly-laundry-detergent-a8349611828/>
- [2] NY DEC: 1,4-Dioxane Limits for Household Cleansing Products
<https://dec.ny.gov/environmental-protection/help-for-businesses/household-personal-cosmetic-dioxane-limits>
- [3] PubMed: Occupational Asthma Caused by Quaternary Ammonium Compounds (multicenter cohort, JACI In Practice 2021)
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/33940212/>
- [4] PubMed: Quaternary Ammonium Compounds, A Chemical Class of Emerging Concern (Environ Sci Technol 2023)
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/37157132/>
- [5] CDC ATSDR: Public Health Statement for 1,4-Dioxane
<https://www.cdc.gov/TSP/PHS/PHS.aspx?phsid=953&toxid=199>
- [6] PubMed: Determination of 1,4-dioxane in household detergents and cleaners
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/18476359/>
- [7] EPA: Our Current Understanding of the Human Health and Environmental Risks of PFAS
<https://www.epa.gov/pfas/our-current-understanding-human-health-and-environmental-risks-pfas>
- [8] ABC News: 3M agrees to \$10.3B settlement over claims it polluted drinking water with 'forever chemicals'
<https://abcnews.com/Health/3m-agrees-103b-settlement-claims-polluted-drinking-water/story?id=100333076>
- [9] NIH/PMC: The Endocrine Disruptor Bisphenol A (BPA) Exerts a Wide Range of Effects
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6864600/>
- [10] NIH/PMC (Environmental Health Perspectives): Bisphenol S and F, a Systematic Review of the Hormonal Activity of BPA Substitutes
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4492270/>
- [11] Canadian Food Inspection Agency: Bisphenol A and BPA Alternatives in Selected Canned Foods and Infant Formula
<https://inspection.canada.ca/food-safety-for-industry/food-chemistry-and-microbiology/food-safety-testing-bulletin-and-reports/final-report/eng/1579821891193/1579821958091>
- [12] European Commission: Commission adopts ban of Bisphenol A in food contact materials (19 December 2024)
https://food.ec.europa.eu/food-safety-news/commission-adopts-ban-bisphenol-food-contact-materials-2024-12-19_en
- [13] Occurrence of the Ochratoxin A Degradation Product 2'R-Ochratoxin A in Coffee and Other Food: An Update (NIH PMC)
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6628416/>
- [14] The concentration and prevalence of ochratoxin A in coffee and coffee-based products: a global systematic review and meta-analysis (PubMed)
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/31345415/>
- [15] FDA final rule, Safety and Effectiveness of Consumer Antiseptics (Federal Register, Sept 6 2016, via GovInfo)
<https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/FR-2016-09-06/pdf/2016-21337.pdf>
- [16] Consumer Reports: Are Any Toothpaste Ingredients Dangerous to Your Health?
<https://www.consumerreports.org/dental-oral-care/are-any-toothpaste-ingredients-dangerous-to-your-health>
- [17] TIME: Most Macaroni and Cheese Products Contain These Chemicals, Study Finds (2017)
<https://time.com/4858541/mac-and-cheese-phthalates-study/>
- [18] Phthalate Exposure and Children's Health (NIH PMC review)
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3747651/>
- [19] Johnson & Johnson to phase out potentially harmful chemicals by 2015 (CBS News/AP, Aug 2012)
<https://www.cbsnews.com/news/johnson-johnson-to-phase-out-potentially-harmful-chemicals-by-2015/>
- [20] Johnson & Johnson Removes Some Chemicals from Baby Shampoo, Other Products (Scientific American, May 2013)
<https://www.scientificamerican.com/article/johnson-and-johnson-removes-some-chemicals-from-baby-shampoo-other-products/>
- [21] 1,4-Dioxane in Cosmetics: A Manufacturing Byproduct (FDA)
<https://www.fda.gov/cosmetics/potential-contaminants-cosmetics/14-dioxane-cosmetics-manufacturing-byproduct>
- [22] Phthalates in Cosmetics (FDA)
<https://www.fda.gov/cosmetics/cosmetic-ingredients/phthalates-cosmetics>
- [23] P&G; Issues Voluntary Recall of Aerosol Dry Conditioner and Dry Shampoo Spray Products (FDA, Dec 17, 2021)
<https://www.fda.gov/safety/recalls-market-withdrawals-safety-alerts/pg-issues-voluntary-recall-aerosol-dry-conditioner-spray-products-and-aerosol-dry-shampoo-spray>
- [24] Unilever Issues Voluntary U.S. Recall of Select Dry Shampoos Due to Potential Presence of Benzene (FDA, Oct 18, 2022)
<https://www.fda.gov/safety/recalls-market-withdrawals-safety-alerts/unilever-issues-voluntary-us-recall-select-dry-shampoos-due-potential-presence-benzene>
- [25] NIH press release: Hair straightening chemicals associated with higher uterine cancer risk (Oct 17, 2022)
<https://www.nih.gov/news-events/news-releases/hair-straightening-chemicals-associated-higher-uterine-cancer-risk>

- [26] Federal Unified Agenda: FDA proposed rule banning formaldehyde in hair smoothing/straightening products (RIN 0910-AI83)
<https://www.reginfo.gov/public/do/eAgendaViewRule?pubId=202304&RIN;=0910-AI83>
- [27] FDA bulletin: P&G; Issues Voluntary Recall of Specific Old Spice and Secret Aerosol Spray Antiperspirants Due to Detection of Benzene (Nov 2021)
<https://content.govdelivery.com/accounts/USFDA/bulletins/2fe66a4>
- [28] Consumer Reports: Are Any Toothpaste Ingredients Dangerous to Your Health? (confirms Colgate Total reformulated triclosan-free as Total SF)
<https://www.consumerreports.org/dental-oral-care/are-any-toothpaste-ingredients-dangerous-to-your-health>
- [29] PMC systematic review: The Influence of Triclosan on the Thyroid Hormone System in Humans
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9202756/>
- [30] NRDC, Clearing the Air: Hidden Hazards of Air Fresheners (Sept 2007, full PDF with brand-by-brand results table)
<https://www.nrdc.org/sites/default/files/airfresheners.pdf>
- [31] Environmental Health Perspectives (NIH/PMC): Scented Products Emit a Bouquet of VOCs
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3018511/>
- [32] PubMed: A standard method for measuring benzene and formaldehyde emissions from candles in emission test chambers for human health risk assessment
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23695106/>
- [33] Scientific Reports (NIH/PMC): Impact of scented candle use on indoor air quality and airborne microbiome
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11933706/>
- [34] US EPA Pesticide Product Label, Clorox Disinfecting Wipes, EPA Reg. No. 5813-79 (03/04/2022)
https://www3.epa.gov/pesticides/chem_search/ppls/005813-00079-20220304.pdf
- [35] PubMed: Occupational exposure patterns to disinfectants and cleaning products and asthma among French healthcare workers (CONSTANCES, n=5,512)
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/40268382/>
- [36] Federal Register, Jan 16 2025: FDA revokes color additive listing for FD&C; Red No. 3 in food and ingested drugs (govinfo)
<https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/FR-2025-01-16/html/2025-00830.htm>
- [37] California AB 418, The California Food Safety Act (bans red dye 3 in food statewide starting Jan 1, 2027)
https://leginfo.ca.gov/faces/billNavClient.xhtml?bill_id=202320240AB418
- [38] Impact of Skin Care Products on Phthalates and Phthalate Replacements in Children: the ECHO-FGS (Environmental Health Perspectives, 2024, NIH PMC full text)
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11373421/>
- [39] EPA Report on the Environment: Urinary Phthalates (CDC NHANES biomonitoring data, U.S. population age 6 and up)
<https://cfpub.epa.gov/roe/indicator.cfm?i=67>
- [40] Are Sleeping Children Exposed to Plasticizers, Flame Retardants, and UV-Filters from Their Mattresses? Environmental Science & Technology, 2025 (NIH PMC full text)
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12044681/>
- [41] University of Toronto: researcher finds children's mattresses off-gas chemicals (April 2025)
<https://www.utoronto.ca/news/u-t-researcher-draws-international-headlines-after-finding-children-s-mattresses-gas-chemicals>

YOUR NEXT STEP

Want to know which of these are in YOUR home?

Take the free 3 minute Home Scan. It walks your house room by room and shows you your score.

scan.ismyhometoxic.com/now

LINKS AND MORE

The free 3 minute Home Scan

<https://scan.ismyhometoxic.com/now/>

Your First Switch, a free 10 minute call with me

<https://link.switchtoamerica.com/widget/bookings/maketheswtch>

Switch to America

<https://switchtoamerica.com/>

*From me to you: I went through my own house one room at a time. I am not asking you to throw everything out. Start with one thing, then work down the list. You are not behind, you are just getting started. See you inside the scan. **Shannon Nicole**, Founder*